

Every Algebraic Number is a Critical Value of an Integer Polynomial

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Abstract

For every irreducible $f \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$ of positive degree we construct $g \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$ and an irreducible $F \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$ with $F \mid g'$ and $F^2 \mid f \circ g$. Equivalently, every algebraic number is a critical value of an integer polynomial, so the set of critical values of $\mathbb{Z}[x]$ is exactly $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}$. The construction is explicit. The proof was assisted by AI, and has been formalized in Lean.

1 Introduction

A critical value of a nonconstant $g \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$ is a number α with $g(\beta) = \alpha$ and $g'(\beta) = 0$ for some β . Since $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}$ is closed under polynomial evaluation, every critical value is algebraic. Johannes Walcher posed the problem of establishing the reverse implication. This note solves Walcher's problem with an explicit construction.

Theorem 1. *Let f be an irreducible integral polynomial of positive degree. Then there exist F and g in $\mathbb{Z}[x]$, with F irreducible and of positive degree, such that*

$$F \mid g' \quad \text{and} \quad F^2 \mid f \circ g.$$

The corollary is the statement in the title.

Corollary 1. *The set of critical values is exactly $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}$.*

pf. Write $f = m_\alpha$. If $g(\beta) = \alpha$ and $g'(\beta) = 0$ then β is a double root of $f \circ g$, since $(f \circ g)' = (f' \circ g)g'$; so $m_\beta \mid g'$ and $m_\beta^2 \mid f \circ g$. Conversely take F and g from Theorem 1: a root β of F has $g'(\beta) = 0$ and $f(g(\beta)) = 0$, so $g(\beta)$ is a conjugate of α , and conjugation gives α itself. ■

2 The construction

Let f be irreducible of degree $n \geq 1$ and α a root. Write $f(x) = \sum_{k=0}^n a_k x^{n-k}$, so that $a_n = f(0)$. If $f = x$, then $g = x^2$ and $F = x$ work. Otherwise $f(0) \neq 0$, and since $\gcd(f, f') = 1$ in $\mathbb{Q}[x]$, the elimination ideal $(f, f') \cap \mathbb{Z}$ is nonzero; let $u, v \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$ and $\rho \in \mathbb{Z}, \rho \neq 0$, be such that $u f + v f' = \rho$, and set $M := \rho a_n$, $F(x) := f(Mx)/a_n$ and $W(x) := (v(0)F(x) - v(Mx))/\rho$. The polynomial claimed by Theorem 1 is

$$g(x) := Mx + f(Mx)W(x). \tag{1}$$

Theorem (restatement of Theorem 1). *F is irreducible, and $F \mid g'$ and $F^2 \mid f \circ g$.*

pf. Write $F(x) = \sum_{k=0}^n A_k x^{n-k}$. From $A_k = a_k M^{n-k}/a_n$ we get $A_n = 1$ and $A_k = a_k \rho^{n-k} a_n^{n-k-1}$ for $k < n$, so $F \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$ with $F(0) = 1$, which gives $W(0) = 0$. And ρ divides M and every A_k with $k < n$, so it divides $v(0)F(x) - v(Mx)$ and $W \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$. Therefore g is an integral polynomial.

Let $\beta = \alpha/M$, a root of F ; therefore $g(\beta) = \alpha$, and $\rho W(\beta) = -v(\alpha)$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} g'(\alpha/M) &= M + \rho a_n f'(\alpha) W(\alpha/M) + \cancel{f(\alpha)} W'(\alpha/M) \\ &= M - a_n f'(\alpha) v(\alpha) = 0, \end{aligned}$$

because $u(\alpha) \cancel{f(\alpha)} + v(\alpha) f'(\alpha) = \rho$. Hence β is a double root of $f \circ g$, and F is primitive irreducible, so $F \mid g'$ and $F^2 \mid f \circ g$ by Gauss. ■

Any ρ will do, but $M = \rho a_n$ multiplies into every coefficient of F , W and g , so the reduced resultant gives the answer with the smallest coefficients.

3 Examples

Each line below is a closed identity, checkable by expansion.

Example 1 ($f = qx - p$, $p \neq 0$, $\gcd(p, q) = 1$). Here $f' = q$ and $p = qx - f$, so $(f, f') \cap \mathbb{Z} = \mathbb{Z}$ and $\rho = 1$. Choose $a, b \in \mathbb{Z}$ with $ap + bq = 1$ and take $u = -a$, $v = ax + b$; then $f(0) = -p$, $M = -p$, $F = qx + 1$, $W = x$, and

$$g = -pqx^2 - 2px, \quad g' = -2p(qx + 1), \quad f \circ g = -p(qx + 1)^2.$$

Example 2 ($f = ax^2 + bx + c$). This is irreducible of degree 2 exactly when $a \neq 0$, $\gcd(a, b, c) = 1$, and $D := b^2 - 4ac$ is not a square. Since $(f')^2 = 4af + D$,

$$\rho = \text{Res}(f, f') = -aD, \quad u = 4a^2, \quad v = -af',$$

so $M = -acD$ and

$$F = a^3cD^2x^2 - abDx + 1, \quad W = a^3bcDx^2 - a(b^2 - 2ac)x,$$

$$g = a^6bc^3D^3x^4 - 2a^4c^2(b^2 - ac)D^2x^3 + a^2bc(b^2 - ac)Dx^2 - 2ac(b^2 - 3ac)x,$$

with $g' = 2ac(2a^2bcDx - (b^2 - 3ac))F$. For $b = 0$ the quartic term drops and $\deg g = 3 = n + 1$, the least any solution can have.

Example 3 ($f = x^3 - x - 1$). The construction gives $M = 23$ and a sextic. A hand-tuned quintic also witnesses the *statement*, and is a useful independent check of it:

$$g = -24334x^5 + 39675x^4 - 26450x^3 + 9085x^2 - 1610x + 118, \quad F = 23x^3 - 23x^2 + 8x - 1,$$

with $g' = -230(23x - 7)F$ and $F^2 \mid f \circ g$, the cofactor having degree 9.

Example 4 (Dedekind's cubic). $f = x^3 - x^2 - 2x - 8$, the standard example of a field whose ring of integers is not monogenic: 2 is a common index divisor [Ded78]. With $u = 21x - 125$, $v = -7x^2 + 44x - 3$, $\rho = 1006$, $f(0) = -8$, $M = -8048$,

$$F = 65158925824x^3 + 8096288x^2 - 2012x + 1, \quad W = -194310912x^3 + 426544x^2 + 358x,$$

$$g = 101288722414414331904x^6 - 209759614012620800x^5 \\ - 217370176548864x^4 - 14767629312x^3 + 2350016x^2 - 10912x.$$

4 Computerization

The construction of g was provided by AI. However, the crucial step that allowed the agent to provide answers was my proof of Corollary 1. Once I recast the problem as the search for an irreducible polynomial F satisfying the hypotheses of Theorem 1, the agent found g for a general linear polynomial (which one can do by hand), then for a general quadratic, then for a general cubic, and finally gave the formula for g for arbitrary f . Previously, all agents I tried failed to construct g for $x^3 - x - 1$.

The development above has been formalized in Lean 4 [MU21] against Mathlib [The20], in about 1,200 lines [Acu26b].

An online calculator is provided for the reader to verify the construction [Acu26a]. It runs the construction in the browser, on the same compiled Haskell, and checks its own output.



the repository



the calculator

References

- [Ded78] Richard Dedekind. “Über den Zusammenhang zwischen der Theorie der Ideale und der Theorie der höheren Kongruenzen”. In: *Abhandlungen der Königlichen Gesellschaft der Wissenschaften zu Göttingen* (1878).
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- [Acu26a] RJ Acuña. *Critical values of integer polynomials: an online calculator*. <https://rjacuna.github.io/CriticalValues/>. 2026.
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